Guess what? She was indeed at the airport, with a ticket and all, at seven in the morning. When she came to me and said she was ready, I couldn't recognize her. Saqlain, who was my wingman the previous night, refreshed my memory, insisting that it was indeed her. I tried to dodge her throughout the check-in process. Make-up and low lights can sometimes do wonderful things to cognition.

And then there are the fans. I love my fans. I love them to bits.

But there are fans and then there are crazy fans. There are also stalkers. And then there are psychopaths. I know fangirls who travelled from villages outside Peshawar and were found in central Karachi – all in search of me. Some turned up dressed as brides at my residence. I actually had to escort them back or send for their parents to come and collect them. I've met some who've carved my name on their arms with a blade. Some women have been stalking me since 1996. A couple of them even follow me on international tours. It's quite flattering but a little crazy. And quite scary.

I remember this instance when one Sunday afternoon – my mother was still alive then – in the off season, our doorbell rang. The attendant came in and told my mother and me that some 'people' were waiting for me outside. I told him to tell the 'people' that it's a holiday and they should call and make an appointment and then come. However, my mother, God bless her soul, was shocked.

'Shahid, guests are a blessing,' she said. 'How dare you turn people away from your door?'

So, I went down to the gate to see two young women just standing there. They introduced themselves and said that there was someone in their car, parked nearby, waiting to talk to me.

I thought it was an old person or someone who couldn't leave their car, so I accompanied them to their vehicle. I peeked inside to say hello and there, in glittery red glory, sat a lovely girl dressed as an all-out bride. I still didn't get it. I figured she might be on the way to her wedding and maybe wanted to take a photograph with me or something. I congratulated her on her upcoming nuptials and she interrupted me and said, 'Shahid, I've come all the way from Peshawar. I'm ready to get married. I want to be your wife. Let's go to the mosque and get married.' Saying so, she grabbed my hand.

Besides being shocked, I was quick on my feet. I politely freed my hand and told her that while I was flattered, I was too young to get married. I thanked her and then sent her off after a few minutes of trying to convince her that she was a beautiful woman and deserved better. Phew!

Then there was this girl who would call often. This was in the '90s, when cellphones were a new thing and very expensive. So this girl started calling, totally out of the blue, and I started blowing a lot of money listening to her on the phone, giving her all the time she wanted because her voice was amazing. She sounded beautiful.

Initially, it was she who would call. Soon, I was the one who started calling her up. Remember, I wasn't married or anything at the time. So finally, I asked her to meet me. She agreed. We decided to meet on Eid in Karachi. I couldn't wait! So when Eid came, I invited her to come over and see me, as my parents would be home. It was like an arranged date!

Finally, on Eid, I couldn't keep my wits about me. The doorbell rang. I went to answer it and opened the door. There stood a young man, no more than fifteen or sixteen years old, holding a bouquet of roses. I was a little confused. So I asked him who he was. I received the shock of my life when he said he was the same 'girl' I had been talking to all these months and whom I was